

False Memory Word List Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 15-20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	15-20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	false-memory-word-list

Big idea: Coherence can produce confident false memory.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students experience how meaning and expectation can create a memory of something that was not presented.

Student Prompt

Inspect False Memory Word List Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

False Memory Word List Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
False Memory Word List Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A second list around sweet foods that omits 'candy' or 'sugar'. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
False Memory Word List Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A recall sheet separating remembered words from inferred words. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Coherence can produce confident false memory.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting False Memory Word List Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from False Memory Word List Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how coherence can produce confident false memory.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A word list around sleep that omits the word 'sleep'.
- A second list around sweet foods that omits 'candy' or 'sugar'.
- A recall sheet separating remembered words from inferred words.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/false-memory-word-list/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/false-memory-word-list/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/false-memory-word-list/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Read the word list aloud once.
2. Students complete a distractor task for one minute.
3. Ask which words they remember. Include the lure word "sleep" on a recognition list.
4. Count how many students confidently remember the lure.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Does a coherent story make a belief feel more true?
- What is the difference between remembering and inferring?
- What does this suggest about legal testimony, history and personal identity?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...